The undisputed facts reveal that the local chapters of the Jaycees are large and basically unselective groups. At the time of the state administrative hearing, the Minneapolis chapter had approximately 430 members, while the St. Paul chapter had about 400. Report, App. to Juris. Statement A–99, A–100. Apart from age and sex, neither the national organization nor the local chapters employ any criteria for judging applicants for membership, and new members are routinely recruited and admitted with no inquiry into their backgrounds. See 1 Tr. of State Administrative Hearing 124–132, 135–136, 174–176. In fact, a local officer testified that he could recall no instance in which an applicant had been denied membership on any basis other than age or sex. *Id.*, at 135. Cf. *Tillman* v. *Wheaton-Haven Recreation Assn., Inc.*, 410 U. S. 431, 438 (1973) (organization whose only selection criterion is race has "no plan or purpose of exclusiveness" that might make it a private club exempt from federal civil rights statute); *Sullivan* v. *Little Hunting Park, Inc.*, 396 U. S. 229, 236 (1969) (same); *Daniel* v. *Paul*, 395 U. S. 298, 302 (1969) (same). Furthermore, despite their inability to vote, hold office, or receive certain awards, women affiliated with the Jaycees attend various meetings, participate in selected projects, and engage in many of the organization's social functions. See Tr. 58. Indeed, numerous nonmembers of both genders regularly participate in a substantial portion of activities central to the decision of many members to associate with one another, including many of the organization's various community programs, awards ceremonies, and recruitment meetings. See, *e. g.*, 305 N. W. 2d, at 772; Report, App. to Juris. Statement A102, A103.

In short, the local chapters of the Jaycees are neither small nor selective. Moreover, much of the activity central to the formation and maintenance of the association involves the participation of strangers to that relationship. Accordingly, we conclude that the Jaycees chapters lack the distinctive characteristics that might afford constitutional protection to the decision of its members to exclude women. We turn

therefore to consider the extent to which application of the Minnesota statute to compel the Jaycees to accept women infringes the group's freedom of expressive association.

B

An individual's freedom to speak, to worship, and to petition the government for the redress of grievances could not be vigorously protected from interference by the State unless a correlative freedom to engage in group effort toward those ends were not also guaranteed. See, *e. g.*, *Citizens Against Rent Control/Coalition for Fair Housing* v. *Berkeley*, 454 U. S. 290, 294 (1981). According protection to collective effort on behalf of shared goals is especially important in preserving political and cultural diversity and in shielding dissident expression from suppression by the majority. See, *e. g. Gilmore* v. *City of Montgomery*, 417 U. S., at 575; *Griswold* v. *Connecticut*, 381 U. S., at 482–485; *NAACP* v. *Button*, 371 U. S. 415, 431 (1963); *NAACP* v. *Alabama ex rel. Patterson*, 357 U. S., at 462. Consequently, we have long understood as implicit in the right to engage in activities protected by the First Amendment a corresponding right to associate with others in pursuit of a wide variety of political, social, economic, educational, religious, and cultural ends. See, *e. g.*, *NAACP* v. *Claiborne Hardware Co.*, 458 U. S. 886, 907–909, 932–933 (1982); *Larson* v. *Valente*, 456 U. S. 228, 244–246 (1982); *In re Primus*, 436 U. S. 412, 426 (1978); *Abood* v. *Detroit Board of Education*, 431 U. S. 209, 231 (1977). In view of the various protected activities in which the Jaycees engages, see *infra*, at 626–627, that right is plainly implicated in this case.

Government actions that may unconstitutionally infringe upon this freedom can take a number of forms. Among other things, government may seek to impose penalties or withhold benefits from individuals because of their membership in a disfavored group, *e. g.*, *Healy* v. *James*, 408 U. S. 169, 180–184 (1972); it may attempt to require disclosure of

the fact of membership in a group seeking anonymity, *e. g.*, *Brown* v. *Socialist Workers '74 Campaign Committee*, 459 U. S. 87, 91–92 (1982); and it may try to interfere with the internal organization or affairs of the group, *e. g.*, *Cousins* v. *Wigoda*, 419 U. S. 477, 487–488 (1975). By requiring the Jaycees to admit women as full voting members, the Minnesota Act works an infringement of the last type. There can be no clearer example of an intrusion into the internal structure or affairs of an association than a regulation that forces the group to accept members it does not desire. Such a regulation may impair the ability of the original members to express only those views that brought them together. Freedom of association therefore plainly presupposes a freedom not to associate. See *Abood* v. *Detroit Board of Education*, *supra*, at 234–235.

The right to associate for expressive purposes is not, however, absolute. Infringements on that right may be justified by regulations adopted to serve compelling state interests, unrelated to the suppression of ideas, that cannot be achieved through means significantly less restrictive of associational freedoms. *E. g.*, *Brown* v. *Socialist Workers '74 Campaign Committee*, *supra*, at 91–92; *Democratic Party of United States* v. *Wisconsin*, 450 U. S. 107, 124 (1981); *Buckley* v. *Valeo*, 424 U. S. 1, 25 (1976) *(per curiam)*; *Cousins* v. *Wigoda*, *supra*, at 489; *American Party of Texas* v. *White*, 415 U. S. 767, 780–781 (1974); *NAACP* v. *Button*, *supra*, at 438; *Shelton* v. *Tucker*, 364 U. S. 479, 486, 488 (1960). We are persuaded that Minnesota's compelling interest in eradicating discrimination against its female citizens justifies the impact that application of the statute to the Jaycees may have on the male members' associational freedoms.

On its face, the Minnesota Act does not aim at the suppression of speech, does not distinguish between prohibited and permitted activity on the basis of viewpoint, and does not license enforcement authorities to administer the statute on the basis of such constitutionally impermissible criteria. See